Steel Magnolias

By Robert Harling

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

ACTRESS 1: M'lynn
ACTRESS 2: Annelle and Shelby

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *M'Lynn is excited to welcome home for the holidays her newly married daughter, Shelby.*
ACTRESS 1: *Shelby, who is diabetic, has come to tell her family that she's expecting a baby and knows her mom is going to be upset because of the danger to her health.*
TOGETHER: *Steel Magnolias by Robert Harling*

M'LYNN: How are you, honey?

SHELBY: I'm so good, Mama. Just great.

M'LYNN: You're looking well. Is Jackson at the house?

SHELBY: No. You know how twitchy he gets. I sent him to look for stocking stuffers.

M'LYNN: Good thinking.

SHELBY: Uh. Jackson and I have something to tell you. We wanted to tell you when you and Daddy were together, but you're never together, so it's every man for himself. I'm pregnant.

M'LYNN: Shelby?!

SHELBY: I'm going to have a baby.

M'LYNN: I realize that.

SHELBY: Well…is that it? Is that all you're going to say?

M'LYNN: I...what do you expect me to say?

SHELBY: Something along the lines of congratulations.

M'LYNN: Congratulations.

SHELBY: Would it be too much to ask for a little excitement? Not too much, I wouldn't want you to break a sweat or anything.

M'LYNN: I'm in a state of shock! I didn't think ...

SHELBY: In June. Oh, Mama. You have to help me plan. We're going to get a new house. Jackson and I are going house hunting next week. Jackson loves to hunt for anything.

M'LYNN: What does Jackson say about this?

SHELBY: Oh. He's very excited. He says he doesn't care whether it's a boy or girl...but I know he really wants a son so bad he can taste it. He's so cute about the whole thing. It's all he can talk about ... Jackson Latcherie Junior.

M'LYNN: But does he ever listen? I mean when doctors and specialists give you advice. I know you never listen, but does he? I guess since he doesn't have to carry the baby, it doesn't really concern him.

SHELBY: Mama. Don't be mad. I couldn't bear it if you were. It's Christmas.

M'LYNN: I'm not mad, Shelby. This is just...hard. I thought that...I don't know.

SHELBY: Mama. I want a child.

M'LYNN: But what about the adoption proceedings? You have filed so many applications.

SHELBY: Mama. It didn't take us long to see the handwriting on the wall. No judge is going to give a baby to someone with my medical track record. Jackson even put out some feelers about buying one.

M'LYNN: People do it all the time.

SHELBY: Listen to me. I want a child of my own. I think it would help things a lot.

M'LYNN: I see.

SHELBY: Mama. I know. I know. Don't think I haven't thought this through. You can't live a life if all you do is worry. And you worry too much. In some ways it's a comfort to me. I never worry because I know you're worrying enough for the both of us. Jackson and I have given this a lot of thought.

M'LYNN: Has he really? There's a first time for everything.

SHELBY: Don't start on Jackson.

M'LYNN: Shelby. Your poor body has been through so much. Why do you deliberately want to ...

SHELBY: Mama. Diabetics have healthy babies all the time.

M'LYNN: You are special. There are limits to what you can do.

SHELBY: Mama. Listen. I have it all planned. I'm going to be very careful. And this time next year, I'm going to be bringing your big healthy grandbaby to the Christmas festival. No one is going to be hurt or disappointed, or even inconvenienced.

M'LYNN: Least of all Jackson, I'm sure.

SHELBY: You are jealous because you no longer have any say-so in what I do. And that drives you up the wall. You're ready to spit nails because you can't call the shots.

M'LYNN: I did not raise my daughter to talk to me this way.

SHELBY: Yes you did. Whenever any of us asked you what you wanted us to be when we grew up, what did you say?

M'LYNN: Shelby, I am not in the mood for games.

SHELBY: What did you say? Just tell me what you said. Answer me.

M'LYNN: I said all I wanted was for you to be happy.

SHELBY: O.K. The thing that would make me happy is to have a baby. If I could adopt one I would, but I can't. I'm going to have a baby. I wish you would be happy, too.

M'LYNN: I wish I...I don' t know what I wish.

SHELBY: Mama. I don't know why you have to make every thing so difficult. I look at having this baby as he opportunity of a lifetime. Sure, there may be some risk involved. That's true for anybody. But you get through it and life goes on. And when it's all said and done there'll be a little piece of immortality with Jackson's looks and my sense of style...I hope. Mama, please. I need your support. I would rather have thirty minutes of wonderful than a lifetime of nothing special. (Pause) Please don't tell anybody yet. I wanna tell daddy first.

TRANSITION

ACTRESS 1: *Shelby has her baby – a beautiful little boy and only 3 months premature, but with the birth came some additional complications*

SHELBY: The doctor's just been trying to strengthen my veins *(shows bruises on her arms)* They're in terrible shape. It's my dialysis. It's not any big thing. No big thing. Don't look at me like that. Having Jack Junior put too much strain on my kidneys and not they're kaput. That's all. The doctors said this would probably happen. I'll just have a kidney transplant and I'll be fine. There are people at dialysis that have been waiting for years. But I'm lucky. I don't have to wait anymore. Mama's going to give me one of her kidneys.

M'LYNN: We haven't known that long. We were all just tested last week. I'm the closest match. There are four categories for an organ match. I matched the best.

SHELBY: Swimsuit, evening gown, talent and personality interview. . . . I'm sorry . . . that's Tommy's joke. I think it's very funny.

M'LYNN: I was just so relieved it was me. The boys are young. I would never want them to go through it. And who would want one of Drum's mean old organs? But! The best thing about all this is that with all the tests and tuff, I have discovered I have the constitution of someone ten years younger. How about that!

SHELBY: My operation's simple. Mama's is awful. They basically have to saw her in half to get the kidney. It's major, major surgery for her.

M'LYNN: They do it on "Circus of the Stars" all the time.

SHELBY: *(with a sad smile at her mother's joke)* There have been more than enough tears.

M'LYNN: I'm happy. Look at the opportunity I have. Most mothers only get the chance to give their child life once. I get a chance to do it twice. Poor Shelby . . . .

SHELBY: *(firmly)* Don't say that. I have my baby. I'm very happy. If this is a part of the price I have to pay, then I have to pay it. I can deal with it . . .

TRANSITION

ACTRESS 2: *Nearly a year later . . . .*
ACTRESS 1: *And the price to be paid turns out to be much higher than expected. . .*
ACTRESS 2: *Annelle, a friend of the family, tries to provide some comfort*

M'LYNN: After the transplant failed, she went back on dialysis -- She'd been doing fine the last few months. But last Monday, everything went wrong. It was like dominoes. They thought they could correct things with a little surgery. As they wheeled her down, she said, "Mama. I'm going to feel so good when this is over." They gave her the anesthetic.

ANNELLE: In a way she was right. Maybe she knew she was going to be with her king.

M'LYNN: *(a little shaken)* Yes, Annelle. Maybe so.

ANNELLE: We should be rejoicing.

M'LYNN: You go ahead. I wish I could feel that way. I guess I'm a little selfish. I'd rather have her here.

ANNELLE: Miss M'Lynn. I don't mean to upset you by saying that. You see, when something like this happens, I pray very hard to make heads or tails of it. I think in Shelby's case, she wanted to take care of that baby, of you, of

everybody she knew . . . and her poor body was just worn out. It wouldn't let her do everything she wanted to do. So she went on to a place where she could be a guardian angel. She will always be young. She will always be beautiful. And I personally feel much safer knowing she's up there on my side. I know some people might think that sounds real simple and stupid . . .and maybe I am. But that's how I get through things like this.

M'LYNN: *(gentler)* Thank you, Annelle. I appreciate that. Shelby, would not want us to get all mired down and wallow in this. She would look on it as just one of life's occurrences.

(Annelle fades and is replaced by Shelby)

SHELBY: I'm going to have a baby. *(echos)*

M'LYNN: We should deal with it the best way we know how . . . and get on with it.

SHELBY: Would it be too much to ask for a little excitement? *(echoes)*

M'LYNN: That's what my mind says. I wish somebody would explain that to my heart. *(BEAT – remembering)*

SHELBY: Mama. I want a child of my own. I think it would help things a lot. *(echoes)*

M'LYNN: I couldn't leave my Shelby. I just sat there and kept pushin' the way I always have where Shelby was concerned.... I was hopin' she'd sit up and argue with me. Finally we realized there was no hope.

SHELBY: Mama. You can't live a life if all you do is worry. And you worry too much. In some ways it's a comfort to me. I never worry because I know you're worrying enough for the both of us. *(3choes)*

M'LYNN: They turned off the machines. *(Pause)*

SHELBY: Mama. Diabetics have healthy babies all the time. *(echoes)*

M'LYNN: Drum left.. couldn't take it. Jackson left. *(Slight "laugh")* I find it amusin'.. men are supposed to be made outta steel or somethin. I just sat there. I just held Shelby's hand.

SHELBY: No one is going to be hurt or disappointed, or even inconvenienced. *(echoes)*

M'LYNN: Oh God.. I realize as a woman how lucky I am! I was there when that beautiful creature drifted into my life.. and I was there when she drifted out of it. It was the most precious moment of my life... *[Sighs]*

SHELBY: And when it's all said and done there'll be a little piece of immortality with Jackson's looks and my sense of style...I hope. *(echoes)*

M'LYNN: I'm fine.. I'm fine.. I'm fine.. I'm FINE! *[sobbing/screaming]*

SHELBY: Mama, please. I need your support.

M'LYNN: I could jog all the way to Texas and back.. but my daughter can't!! She never could!! Oh.. God . . . I'm so mad I don't know what to do!! I wanna know why! I wanna know WHY Shelby's life is over!! I wanna HOW that baby will EVER know how wonderful his mother was.. Will he EVER know what she went THROUGH for him? Oh God I wanna know WHY? WHY? Lord...I wish I could understand!

SHELBY: I would rather have thirty minutes of wonderful than a lifetime of nothing special. *(echoes)*

M'LYNN: No...NO...NO!! It's not supposed to happen this way! I'm supposed to go first!! I've always been ready to go first! I don't think I can take this.. I.. I don't think I can take this! I just wanna hit somethin'! I just wanna hit somebody.. till they feel as bad as I do!! I just wanna hit something!

SHELBY: But you get through it and life goes on. *(Echoes)*

FOR

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AWARD HISTORY

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